



Directionless descent: Despite experience and expectation, the Indian women's team faltered across the European leg of the FIH Pro League — lacking leadership, structure, and spark. GETTYIMAGES

PRO LEAGUE STRUGGLES EXPOSE DEEPER WOES IN INDIAN HOCKEY

A **difficult European leg** for Indian hockey in the FIH Pro League 2024-25 ends with the men barely surviving and the women facing relegation.

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A month is a long time in sport. Before the men and women left for the European leg of the FIH Pro League 2024-25, Indian hockey appeared to be on the right track for the bigger, tougher challenges looming over the next 18 months. By the time they wrapped up a forgettable tour, however, both players and coaches were left grappling with more questions than answers.

The men, who were third with 15 points after the first round of eight home games in Bhubaneswar, managed to add just three more during their final European stretch to finish eighth in the nine-team competition. They suffered the ignominy of a record seven-match losing streak — the longest ever for the Indian men's team across all competitions — slipping from title contenders to a side merely relieved to cling on to its top-tier status, owed more to Ireland's dismal run than India's own doing.

The women weren't so fortunate.

Having earned promotion from the Nations Cup — the second tier of the Pro League — two seasons ago, the team finished bottom and was relegated. It has been replaced by Ireland, which was promoted through the FIH Hockey Nations Cup played in Chile earlier this year. While New Zealand won that tournament, the Black Sticks later declined the invitation to join the Pro League this time. As per tournament regulations, the runner-up — Ireland — was offered the vacant slot, and it has confirmed its participation.

With just two outright wins, and